and almost paranoid terms, but not without a degree of morality. Indeed, it suggests practical reasons for the moderate use of force, engages questions of dharma, and emphasizes the economic aspects of governance. The *Arthashastra* also offers detailed descriptions of a sophisticated state apparatus—including taxation, judicial processes, resource extraction, trade networks, and private enterprise—as well as a rich and complex society featuring spies, slaves, courtesans, and tribal leaders. At the same time, the treatise offers few contemporary historical examples, some references appear anachronistic and its authorship remains questionable. Although the author is identified in the text as both Kautilya and Vishnugupta, the *Arthashastra* has come to be associated with the popular figure of Chanakya. After being lost for centuries, it was rediscovered only in 1905 in Mysuru by R. Shamasastry, who came by the Sanskrit document written in the South Indian *Grantha* script. Later manuscript discoveries have further contributed to our present-day understanding of the text. [12]

The Shungas, who succeeded the Mauryas in the second century BCE continued some of their predecessors' international engagement. This is evidenced by a remarkable inscription in Besnagar in today's Madhya Pradesh from about 100 BCE, in which Heliodorus, the ambassador of the Greek king in Takshashila (Taxila), dedicates an inscribed pillar to the Shunga king Bhagabadhra; it is a potent symbol of early Indian diplomacy. This period also sees evidence of trade in Bengal with Southeast Asia (Java) and several other regions, especially through the port of Tamralipti.

Somewhat later, in the first century CE, the Kushans came to India from Central Asia, often depicting themselves in Central Asian attire, and reflecting religious iconography from India, Persia, and Greece in their coinage. Kushan rule at times covered much of Afghanistan and parts of Central Asia and Xinjiang. The dynasty reached its apex under Kanishka, who like Ashoka was a major patron of Buddhism and who sent missionaries to Kashgar and Yunnan, among other places. Meanwhile, the roughly contemporaneous Satavahana rulers in peninsular India minted coins showing double-masted ships, suggesting a seafaring tradition. [13] It was in this broad period also that numerous *Dharmashastras* were